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Published by

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Estimated reading time

3 min

Added on

2026-06-12

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/football/2026/jun/11/itv-delivers-feisty-start-to-coverage-and-taunts-bbc-from-glitzy-studio>

ITV delivers feisty start to World Cup coverage – and taunts BBC from glitzy studio

Don't mention the war. Mark Pougatch mentioned it, right at the start of ITV's World Cup coverage, but I think he got away with it. He also, to his credit, highlighted the [outrageous ticket prices](#), as well as the [disgraceful treatment](#) of the teams, fans and officials who now find themselves persona non grata in the US. Even Donald J Trump, [the first \(and quite possibly last\) holder of the Fifa Peace Prize](#), got a mention. Pougatch also gave a visibly emotional Ian Wright the chance to suggest that the US has "no idea of the spirit of the game". All unexpectedly and encouragingly feisty.

Of course, it was no Gary Lineker, railing against the hosts' human rights record while launching the BBC's coverage of Qatar 2022. But Lineker is a corporation ghost now – no longer at the Beeb [but podcasting for Netflix](#). The BBC have, on the grounds of cost, opted to present this World Cup [from an austerity bunker in Salford](#). The Telegraph derided this as a "work from home" operation. ITV are already having some fun with it too.

Pougatch began the broadcast striding ostentatiously through downtown New York. The studio, with interior vaguely resembling an open-plan version of the Friends apartment, offers "a great view of Lower Manhattan". Take it down a notch, Mark. You're presenting football from it, not trying to sell it to a merchant banker.

Mystifyingly, there's a second sofa situation on the roof, which involves Semra Hunter and Man v Food refugee Adam Richman offering lighthearted colour. At this early stage, it seems to exist only as a means of further taunting the [BBC](#) with the studio's view of the Brooklyn Bridge, and may not

survive a month in the irritable company of Roy Keane. Expect to see the sofa bobbing around in the Hudson River by the middle of next week.

Anyway, enough of grumpy old Roy. It's off to the Azteca Stadium in Mexico City (the US, of course, aren't the only hosts) for Mexico v South Africa. We're greeted by the insufferable rictus grin of Fifa's Gianni Infantino, but let's gloss over that. That's because Jon Champion and Ally McCoist are there too, and McCoist in particular will not be dialling it down. This is a man who can hyperventilate with excitement over a UEFA Conference League tie between Crystal Palace and Shakhtar Donetsk. How on earth will he be coping with the opening game of a [World Cup](#)? Let's just say he may be needing a new thesaurus.

Still, there's anticipation and emotion in the air and, in the context of the overpowering (and understandable) cynicism that dominated the buildup to this tournament, that's refreshing. [ITV](#) managed just about the right balance between acknowledgment of the issues that seem likely to make this tournament a guilty watch for many, and excitement about the essence of it, which remains just about intact.

Earlier, there was a discussion of the legendary 1970 final that was also played at the Azteca. Ian Wright positively glowed while talking about going round to a mate's house and watching it in colour. ITV also showed a moving short film about Sir Geoff Hurst, the last man standing from the boys of 1966. It was a reminder that the World Cup is special to so many of us, and that is precisely why Fifa's casual contempt for its magic has been so dismaying.

We shouldn't let them have it. At the start of the coverage, Pougatch said something charmingly gauche: "Essentially, football is great." Deep down, everyone watching knows this to be true. It was for the best that the opening salvo of this tournament took place away from the oppressive air of 2026 US.

This is Mexico and Canada's party too, and for all of the problems – which ITV and the BBC must be brave enough to draw attention to when they arise – it's still the World Cup. When Mexico took the lead, the electricity in the air was palpable. Sorry BBC, but being there may turn out to be important after all. Not even Donald Trump can ruin this. Can he?

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